

Trophy

Baker Leads by Seven, Loses by Eight

David Mullin never finished a round worse than second of five, and when the defending champion came apart between the 9th and the 16th at Bletchingley there was only one man in position to pick it up.

David Mullin won the TEG 4 Trophy at +9 net against par, eight clear of Jon Baker. It is the lowest Trophy total recorded in TEG history, and his own best. He managed it by declining, at any stage, to do anything of interest: rounds of 91, 94, 88 and 91 at Ashdown, Lingfield, Crowborough and Bletchingley, and no collapse requiring explanation. In this company, that amounts to a philosophical position.

The drama belonged to Baker, and it travelled in the opposite direction. He arrived at the final round at Bletchingley in contention, birdied the par-3 2nd to move into the outright lead, and then eagled the par-4 8th, a two on a hole he was getting a shot at, and the only eagle struck by anyone in TEG 4. He stood on the summit, seven ahead, surveying the view. Nobody had told him the summit was a ledge.

What followed occupied eight holes. Baker played 9 through 16 in 27 shots over par, and the itemisation has a certain grandeur: double bogeys at the 9th, 13th and 16th, triple bogeys at the 10th, 11th and 14th, a nine at the par-3 12th and an eleven at the par-5 15th. Both of those are the worst he has made on a par 3 and a par 5. He went seven consecutive holes, the 9th to the 15th, without a net par. He never stopped playing golf. He simply stopped scoring at it. David Mullin went ahead at the 12th, where Baker took his nine, and was never caught. He finished eight clear.

The round finished at +9 net, a 12-shot swing from his -3 at Crowborough the day before. His gross total of +113 was still a personal best, which is the sort of consolation one accepts quietly and does not mention again.

AT A GLANCE
Trophy Winner David Mullin (2nd Trophy) Runner-up: Jon Baker
Green Jacket David Mullin (3rd Jacket) Runner-up: Stuart Neumann
Wooden Spoon Gregg Williams (1st Spoon) Next above: Henry Meller

FINAL · Trophy
DM +9 JB +17 SN +28 HM +35 GW +40
FINAL · Green Jacket
DM +81 SN +100 HM +107 JB +113 GW +152

Green Jacket | David Mullin

Nineteen Clear: Mullin Makes It Three

Top of the gross after every round, Mullin's +81 is the lowest total TEG has seen — and Stuart Neumann's personal-best +100 was nowhere near it.

David Mullin won the TEG 4 Green Jacket with a gross total of +81, the lowest gross aggregate recorded in TEG to that point and the best of his own career. The margin was 19 strokes over Stuart Neumann. Eighty-one shots more than the four courses asked for, and it was the finest golf TEG had seen. The standard is what it is.

The four rounds of the 2011 tournament took the field around East Sussex and Surrey, none of the courses previously visited: Royal Ashdown Forest, Lingfield Park, Crowborough Beacon and

Bletchingley. Mullin's card read 91 at Ashdown, 94 at Lingfield, 88 at Crowborough and 91 at Bletchingley. No round worse than 94, and only one above 91.

The Crowborough round was the centrepiece. Mullin's 88 there came in at +17 against par, the second-best gross round in TEG history at the time, and it was his only sub-90 score of the trip. Crowborough, a heathland course with eight holes redesigned by Alister MacKenzie, gave up nothing similar to anyone else.

Neumann's tournament deserves separating from the margin. His +100 gross total was a personal best, built on rounds of 96, 99, 94 and 94, improving in each of the last three rounds. In most editions that would have been a competitive number. Here it was second place by nineteen, comfortably clear of the rest, and never once within hailing distance of the Jacket. He did everything that was asked of him. It was simply the wrong tournament to do it in.

Wooden Spoon | Gregg Williams

Twenty-Eight Blow-Ups Buy One Spoon

Gregg Williams slid from third to fifth over four rounds, set an all-time TEG record for triple-bogeys-plus and finished 5 adrift of Henry Meller, who had taken the last two Spoons.

Gregg Williams finished the 2011 trip to East Sussex and Surrey at +40 net against par, which was enough to hand him the TEG 4 Wooden Spoon. The number that will outlast the result is 28. That is how many triple bogeys or worse he assembled across four rounds. It is an all-time TEG record, and it is not a close one.

They arrived in clusters. At Royal Ashdown Forest in round one he bled 22 shots over the closing nine holes, with four triple bogeys among them. At Crowborough he lost 18 shots in the first six holes, including quadruple bogeys at the 2nd, 4th and 5th; by the time he walked to the 7th tee he was eighteen over for the day and had played six holes. The final round at Bletchingley was the worst of it: a triple, a quad and a nine at the par-five 6th cost 13 shots in four holes, and the closing stretch from the 13th leaked another 16. The round came in at +15 net and +43 gross, both the worst of his career to date.

The bottom of the Spoon race did change hands late. Williams dropped to last at the 6th in the final round, and Henry Meller relieved him of the position at the 11th with a ten at the par five. The relief proved temporary. Williams was holding it at the end.

One consolation: his gross aggregate of +152 was, at that point, the best he had recorded. A personal best constructed almost entirely from triple bogeys is still a personal best.

The Par Threes

The Par Threes Did the Damage

Henry Meller's 12 at Ashdown's 11th is the worst hole relative to par TEG has recorded, and at Bletchingley the shortest, easiest hole on the course was where Jon Baker's Trophy went.

For all the length on offer across the four courses of TEG 4, the damage in 2011 was done on the holes nobody feared.

The largest single number came early. On the opening Monday at Royal Ashdown Forest, Henry Meller reached the 11th, a par three and the third-hardest hole on the card, and signed for a 12. Nine over par on one hole. Eight over after his shot allowance. It stands as the worst score relative to par that Meller has recorded on any hole, and the worst any player managed relative to par in TEG 4. There is no method of taking twelve shots at a par three that involves haste.

The final round at Bletchingley produced two more, and neither came at a hole that was supposed to cause trouble. Jon Baker took nine at the 12th, a par three carrying stroke index 18, the easiest hole on the course. That is six over par, five over net, and the heaviest hole of Baker's career to that point. Two holes later, at the 14th, another short hole and stroke index 16, Gregg Williams made seven for a quadruple bogey.

Between them, three par threes cost 19 shots against par across the four days. Bletchingley, a Paul Wright parkland course being played by the group for the first time, gave up two of them in the space of three holes on the closing day. It had presumably expected a warmer introduction.

Henry Meller

Two Tens and Still Not Last

Henry Meller opened with the worst hole in TEG history and kept dropping to the bottom of the Spoon race, but a personal-best +107 gross and Gregg Williams's final-round ruin left him 5 clear.

Henry Meller left East Sussex in 2011 with the best gross aggregate of his career, +107 across the four rounds of the TEG 4 Green Jacket. The route there was not steady so much as tectonic.

It began at Royal Ashdown Forest, where the par-three 11th cost him a 12, nine over on a single hole, the worst score against par of his career and the worst by anyone in TEG 4. He recovered to sign for 100 there, then produced his lowest round of the trip at Lingfield, 92, built partly on three straight pars at the 9th, 10th and 11th. For a few minutes he looked like a man who had solved something. A nine at the 15th withdrew the suggestion.

Crowborough went backwards. From two over net in round two he slipped to 13 over net in round three, dropping five shots to his handicap across the 13th, 14th and 15th alone, and posting 102.

The final round at Bletchingley delivered both his lowest gross of the trip, 96, and its most damaging passage: 11 shots lost from the 8th to the 11th, including a 10 at the 11th, with another 10 following at the 15th. The quintuple bogey at the 11th also pushed him from fourth to last in the TEG 4 Wooden Spoon standings. He had done all that work to be fourth from bottom, and gave it away on one hole.

Records & Personal Bests

Notable achievements: TEG 4

TEG Records

— David Mullin's +17 (gross) is the 2nd-best Gross round in TEG history to date (R3)

Personal Worsts

— Gregg Williams's worst round to date: +15 (R4)

— Gregg Williams's worst Gross round to date: +43 (R4)

— Jon Baker's worst round to date: +9 (R2)

Rare Feats

— Henry Meller runs up a 12 (+9) at the 11th (R1) — a new TEG-record and career-worst on a par-3

— Jon Baker runs up an 11 (+6) at the 15th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-5

— Jon Baker runs up a 9 (+6) at the 12th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-3

— Jon Baker eagles the par-4 8th (R4)

— Henry Meller runs up a 10 (+5) at the 15th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-5

— Henry Meller runs up a 10 (+5) at the 11th (R4) — his career-worst on a par-5